DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

What Is the Fire of Gehinnom?

Derech Hashem 2:2:4

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 2, paragraph 4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 29 April 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: the community of the perfect

The ultimate goal is to cleave to Hashem in the World to Come, with what the Ramhal calls, for the first time, the Kibbutz HaShelemim, the gathering of the perfect.

The problem is that free will produces both good and bad people, and also makes most people's deeds a mixture. "There isn't one saddik who doesn't sin." Going by the majority would not be fair, since it ignores the saddik's bad and the rasha's good. So there are two times. If you are essentially good with some bruises, they are dealt with in this world. If you are essentially bad with some good deeds, those are repaid with a good life in this world.

How can the reward of a misvah, which is so great, be repaid in this world? The Rabbi recalled the answer from Monday. As the Rambam says, one who does even one misvah perfectly in his life is guaranteed a share in the World to Come. The rasha who is pushed away never did such a misvah: all his good deeds were for financial or social gain, and those can be repaid in this world.

The man who changed in a moment

A participant asked whether a rasha can still repent. "Of course." A person is judged by the state in which he dies, not by everything he did in his life. The Rabbi recalled the man in the Gemara who lived a whole life of debauchery, and in his last moments did teshuvah and was declared worthy of the World to Come. People get upset at this, but "you don't know what level of the World to Come he got." That moment made him who he really was. He will have a great deal of bad to deal with, but he has a portion; how big, "I've got no idea."

What is the source for the Rambam's statement? A participant asked how the Rambam can say this without a verse. The Rabbi said it follows philosophically, and ties in with what we learned in Part 1: there is no reward for a misvah in the sense of "X gets you Y." The reward of the misvah is the misvah itself; you become a better person. If you have done one true misvah, there is real good within you, and that cannot be erased.

Is being cut off really a punishment, if you are not aware of it? The Rabbi said there are two readings, and he has discussed it with hakhamim. The simple reading, which he believes is the

Ramhal's meaning, is that the person simply loses consciousness and identity. There is no punishment as such: Hashem wants good for us, and if you do not merit it, nothing is left. Some hakhamim understand that the person loses his identity but keeps enough awareness to know he has lost it. The Rabbi did not think one has to say that: "perpetual suffering for what?"

Why suffering cleanses

The Gemara in Berakhot compares suffering to salt. Meat with blood is not kosher, and salt makes it kosher. In the same way, a person sins through his body, and what gives the body the energy to act is the blood. So whatever weakens the physical self, whether illness, stress or loss, is a way of atonement for the sin committed with that same energy. A participant connected this to the Gemara's phrase yissurin shel meruk, sufferings that scour.

This is also the root of fasting. The Rabbi cited the teaching of the Arizal, through Rabbi Hayim Vital, that affliction taken on voluntarily achieves more than affliction that simply happens to you. If Hashem left you stranded without food for a day, that cleanses; if you fast voluntarily for a day, it cleanses more. But this must be balanced: as we learned in the Rambam, we must also enjoy the world. "Asceticism in itself is wrong. But this is not asceticism. This is tikkun."

Gan Eden and Gehinnom

The Rabbi recalled from Part 1 that Gan Eden is not the World to Come. "Gan Eden is the waiting room," where the soul is by itself until the world is renewed and the soul reunites with the body. A saddik who dies now goes to Gan Eden in the meantime.

The Ramhal now adds that Hashem wanted to give even more chances for people to succeed. There are people with a great deal of evil in them, but not so much that they must be lost entirely. For them the cleansing of this world is not enough, so there is another department: punishments in the world of souls, the most prominent of which is Gehinnom. It cleanses a person for his sins, exactly like the sufferings of this world but at a far deeper and more intense level, and afterwards he can receive the good.

The Rabbi asked not to call such people reshaim. A true rasha is not sent to Gehinnom; there is no point in cleansing someone who has no life in the World to Come. "If you're going to Gehinnom, you are ben Olam HaBa."

Why twelve months?

This explains why Gehinnom lasts at most twelve months, and why we say Kaddish for that period. We do find statements about eternal punishment, but the reconciliation is simple. No one who is going to the World to Come needs more than twelve months of cleansing. If your bad needs more than that, you are intrinsically bad and will not be sent to Gehinnom at all. For one person it may be a month, for another a week.

Fire and snow

What is the "fire" of Gehinnom? The Gemara has graphic descriptions which are obviously not literal. The way the Rabbi was taught from a young age is that the fire is the burning heat of

embarrassment: think of someone caught in a scandal and the shame he feels, and intensify it. "There's no flames up there." Souls cannot burn. And sometimes embarrassment is so deep that you freeze to the spot, which is why Hazal describe Gehinnom both as fire and as snow.

He compared the levels of cleansing to kashering utensils for Pesah. Something that cannot be kashered at all is thrown away: the real rasha who is cut off. Some things need libbun gamur, intense burning: the full twelve months of Gehinnom. Others need a lighter libbun: a shorter time. And glass dishes are simply washed: the person who loses a little money, is embarrassed a little, is unwell a little, and is cleansed in this world.

Should one say Kaddish for someone who seemed openly wicked? "100%, no question about it." It is not for us to judge who is a rasha: "Do not judge your fellow until you reach his place." Only Hashem weighs all the variables.

Very few are lost

The Rabbi asked everyone to remember the next line. Between these two mechanisms, this world and Gehinnom, the number of people who are truly lost is very small. Almost everyone has done something good enough to have a portion, even if small. Only someone so overcome by evil that eternal reward is impossible will be lost.

The result is three stages: the main one is the world after the resurrection; before that, some deeds are dealt with in this world, and some in the world of souls, a broad term covering both Gan Eden and Gehinnom.

The Rabbi previewed the next class: a difficult idea "hijacked by the Christians," whether another person can help you spiritually. "Don't just listen to the shiur. Think about these ideas."

Summary

- One truly pure misvah guarantees a share in the World to Come; a person is judged by who he is at the end.
- Suffering cleanses like salt koshering meat, by weakening the energy with which we sinned.
- Gehinnom is for people who are basically good but carry much bad; anyone who goes there is destined for the World to Come, which is why it lasts at most twelve months.
- Its "fire" is the burning of shame, and its "snow" the freezing of shame, not literal flames.
- Very few are entirely lost, and we must never judge who is a rasha.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/Dv8aPq9X-dE · More shiurim: rabbikada.com